



“India doesn’t need to outscale others in AI—it needs to outthink the problem. The real leap will be defined by adoption”

PIYUSH GOVIL
CEO, SPANDA AI



“India’s approach is a build-versus-buy balance. Smaller, distilled AI models, trained with the right data and context, can perform effectively”

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32 |

ample, with millions of people more comfortable speaking their own language than typing, voice is emerging as the primary interface for AI adoption. Voice agents are already handling interactions across languages, powering customer support, assisted sales, tutoring, and commerce. ElevenLabs, which focuses on AI audio research and technology, supports 12 Indian languages and has introduced local data residency to meet compliance and latency needs.

AI-powered mixed reality platform Flam AI is building an AI backbone for brands to create and deliver content that bridges physical and digital worlds. Bengaluru-based Gnani.ai, founded by former Texas Instruments engineers, focuses on speech and conversational AI embedded in banking, telecom, healthcare and other sectors. Spanda AI emphasises domain-specific, multilingual sys-

tems that address challenges in education, healthcare, enterprise workflows and governance.

While start-ups are scaling the game, they insist India should chart its own AI course. “India doesn’t need to outscale others in AI—it needs to outthink the problem,” says Piyush Govil, CEO of Spanda AI. The real leap, he says, will be defined by adoption: when AI becomes embedded in classrooms, labs, MSMEs, and public institutions at a low cost.

IMPACT ON OTHER SECTORS

AI is also emerging as a force to strengthen governance and enhance citizens’ quality of life. Rakesh Kaul Punjabi, Partner and AI Activation Leader at EY India, says, “A central pillar of India’s AI strategy is the India AI Mission, backed by over ₹10,300 crore across five years to democratise AI infrastructure.” India has deployed more than 38,000 GPUs for shared compute access across public research, start-ups and academia, with plans to establish 600 AI data labs nationwide.

AI-enabled solutions are expanding healthcare through telemedicine and diagnostics, personalising education via adaptive learning, and securing financial systems with fraud detection. For example, under the tuberculosis (TB) elimination programme, the ‘Cough against TB’ (CATB) initiative uses AI to screen for pulmonary TB in community settings. Between March 2023 and November 2025, CATB screened over 1.62 lakh people, detecting 12–16% more TB cases compared to conventional methods.

Beyond healthcare, AI is driving sustainable agriculture through crop prediction, precision farming and drone monitoring. In governance, it is improving service delivery, translating court judgments, and enhancing everyday efficiency.

Singh of MeitY says “a strong focus is being placed on citizen-centric AI applications and voice-first models that reflect India’s linguistic diversity and enable wider adoption.”

RISKS TO AI: BOOM OR BUST

As global firms lure experienced researchers, talent drain remains a concern. Geopolitical tensions around chips and data flows could disrupt supply chains. And AI infrastructure demands patient, multi-year capital.

Perhaps the biggest threat, several executives warn, is fragmentation: stop-start policies, short-term thinking, and chasing hype over deployment. AI, unlike apps, does not reward impulsive cycles.

So, can India make the big leap in AI in 2026? It depends on how the leap is defined. It is unlikely to unveil